

Intramural Sports and How Students Find Their Place

For many students at the University of Oklahoma, intramural sports provide more than competition, they provide community.

“Yeah, most definitely,” said OU student Steve George when asked if he would recommend Intramurals to new students, “If you want to get better, if you want to have an experience, I definitely recommend it.”

At a school with tens of thousands of students, it can be tough for new students to navigate a way to find their community and build relationships. The Intramural Sports program isn’t all about success on the court, but also about success in finding connections.

“It’s more about the connections that matter,” said Jonathan Dewhirst, the Director of Intramural Sports. “We’re just an outlet for students to get some recreation and some enjoyment, some fulfillment from their life an hour or two a week.”

One part of the intramurals that is friendly to newer players is the two leagues in place: residential and open.

“There are two leagues, residential and open,” George said. “Obviously, if you’re just learning, it’s best to start with residential. Then if you get better, you can move up.”

That structure helps many new students join without the pressure. For some, simply joining a team leads to friendships that extend beyond the field or court. Dewhirst speaks from personal experience. As a college student, he played flag football, soccer, sand volleyball, and slow-pitch softball, usually after friends invited him to join. What started as

casual games turned into lasting relationships. Even 17 years after earning his degree, he remains connected with some of the teammates he met through intramurals.

“If I saw these people, it would be like no time had passed at all,” he said.

Participation in the program grew a lot from 2010-2015, then plateaued. The numbers dropped, of course, like all things, when COVID-19 came along. Dewhirst believes that because COVID shifted social habits and increased reliance on technology, students have a harder time putting themselves out there.

“COVID just ruined people’s social norms,” he said. “Trying to get people out of their little bubbles... putting themselves out there, whether it’s intramural sports or anything, has been more difficult.”

For students unsure where they belong, the message is simple. Try something!

“All you have to do is put yourself out there a little bit,” Dewhirst said.

Looking back on his own college experience, Dewhirst said many students don’t fully understand the impact the people they interact with are having on them in the moment.

“I don’t think people realize in the moment what they get from it,” he said. “Kind of like myself in college, going with my best friend to play two-on-two sand volleyball and meeting two people we had no connection with, or playing soccer at 11 at night in freezing rain. You don’t always realize all the positive qualities it’s adding to your life.”

He said the benefits often go beyond the game itself.

“You’re creating those connections, you’re meeting those people, you’re getting some exercise in, you’re getting that bonding,” he said. “You feel it, you sense it, but a lot of people just aren’t self-aware enough in the moment.”

Sources

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Steve George, OU Student